

America and, after the outbreak of war in September, stayed there, eventually joining Auden in New York. Self-exiles such as Britten and Auden were harshly criticized in Britain for failing to support the war effort against Nazi Germany. But the British authorities had no desire to stir up controversy by persecuting prominent conscientious objectors, and after Britten returned home in 1942—whiling away the journey by writing his choral work *A Ceremony of Carols*—he was left free to continue work as a musician.

The war years were a fertile time for Britten. His output included three notable song cycles—*Les Illuminations* (1940), *Seven Sonnets of Michelangelo* (1942), and the *Serenade for Tenor, Horn, and Strings* (1943)—as well as the *Sinfonia da Requiem* (1940), one of his most successful purely orchestral works. Above all, he produced the score for the opera *Peter Grimes*.

This powerful work brought together two of Britten's deepest sources of inspiration—his love of the coast in the county of Suffolk, where the opera is set, and his sense of isolation as a homosexual, which he expressed through the character of Grimes, who is marginalized and finally driven to his death by a repressive society.

From its first performance in London in 1945, *Peter Grimes* was hailed as a masterpiece. In a series of operas over the following decade, from *The Rape of Lucretia* (1946) and *Albert Herring* (1947) to *Billy Budd* (1951) and *The Turn of the Screw* (1954), Britten in effect reestablished an English operatic tradition that had lapsed since the 17th century. In 1947, he set up